



The Criminal Trade: Your Job

*By working faithfully 8 hours a day, you may eventually
get to be the boss and work 12 hours a day.*

~ ROBERT FROST

I SPENT FIVE YEARS IN COLLEGE . . . FOR A PHONEBOOK?

Before college graduation, I humored myself and attended a few job workshops. One I remember vividly: an entry-level position at a big insurance firm in Chicago. During our introduction at the corporate facility, the company recruiters told us exactly what to expect:

“Over there [pointing to a sea of cubicles] is where our new hires sit. I won’t be coy; in the beginning this job is difficult. We give you three things: a desk, a telephone, and a telephone book. You will spend 10 hours a day cold-calling to build your clientele. I know, not glamorous, but the rewards . . .”

At that point the rewards were inconsequential and I went into acting mode. I acted interested. I acted happy. I acted like it was acceptable. It wasn’t. I spent five years in college just to sit in a 6×6 cubicle and cold-call elderly people out of a damn telephone book? Are you freaking kidding me? I could have done this out of middle school, and I didn’t need to spend thousands on a college degree to hawk insurance. Yet, my peers salivated at the opportunity of having a nice base salary, a great 401K, and a top-tier health plan. No thanks. If I’m cold-calling out of the damn phonebook, it won’t be for my boss, but for me.